Read the short story. Then answer each question.

Mystery of the Broken Pie

The sun was shining on the sparkling grass. It was morning, and the grass was still wet from the dew. We were excited to see the sunshine after days of rain! Sydney and I were tired of being stuck inside.

"Mom, can we go out and play?" I shouted.

"You and Sydney need to clean your rooms first. I'm excited to get some fresh air in the house, it's time for a good spring cleaning!" Mom answered.

Sydney and I looked at each other and groaned. We wanted to get outside, not be stuck inside cleaning. But we knew we could go play as soon as we finished cleaning. We decided to make it a race to see who could clean their room the fastest. But we had to clean up the right way, otherwise Mom would make us redo it.

"3... 2... 1... GO!" we shouted. I picked up all my clothes and put them in my hamper. I tucked in my sheets and pulled the comforter over my bed so it looked like a magazine picture. All of my books went back on the bookshelf, and my toys and games went back in the closet.

"DONE!" I heard Sydney shout from her room down the hall.



"Aw, man, I was just about to shout it out. Good job, Sydney," I said. Sydney jumped up and down. "I never finish cleaning before you, Aiden!" she exclaimed. She looked so excited I couldn't even be mad at my little sister.

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"Let's go outside," I said. We walked into the kitchen, where my mom had all the ingredients out to make her famous apple pie. "Can we go play now?" I asked Mom. "Sure! I'm just going to get this pie in the oven and start cleaning. Make sure you stay in the yard, and if you play nicely, you'll get some pie in a few hours!" she replied.

Sydney and I played in the yard. We rode bikes, played on the swing set, and made up adventures to go on. A couple of hours later, we could smell the pie in the air. "Mmmmm," Sydney said. "I'm hungry. Let's go see if that pie is ready."



When we got in the house, we could hear Mom vacuuming in the living room. Sydney and I walked to the kitchen to see if the pie looked ready. Mom had set the pie to cool by the kitchen window. We peered up at the pie and gasped. It was a mess! The crust on top had holes in it, and the filling was all over the place.

"What happened?" Sydney asked. "Mom's pies never look like that!"

"I don't know, but we'd better figure it out before Mom sees the pie and thinks we did it!" I answered. We ran back outside and sat down under the tree. "What do you think could have happened, Sydney?"

"Hmmm... maybe Mom dropped the pie when she took it out of the oven." Sydney replied.

"Is there evidence for that?" I asked.

"I don't remember, we'd probably have to go back and check around the oven to see if there's a mess."

"Let's think of other possibilities first, then we can go back and search the scene of the crime. I would say that maybe the cat got into the pie, but we don't have a cat, so that can't be it..."

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Sydney and I sat outside for a while, trying to think of ideas. Birds kept flying in and out of the tree above us. They gave me an idea. I looked toward the kitchen, with the wide-open window.

"Hey, I bet that some birds smelled the pie and wanted a piece! It's right by the open window! We should go check for little bird footprints," I said.

"You're right!" Sydney exclaimed. "And if there aren't any footprints, we can look for other clues while we're in the kitchen."

We walked back into the kitchen. Mom was still vacuuming. Sydney and I tiptoed over to the pie to search for evidence. Next to the pie, we saw the filling, and one small footprint.

"That looks like a bird footprint, right?" I asked Sydney. She agreed. We heard the vacuum turn off, and Mom walked into the kitchen.

"What are you two doing by the pie?" she asked.

"We came back in from playing outside and wanted some pie, because it smells delicious. But when we got in here, the pie was a mess!" I said. Sydney added, "We had to solve the mystery of why it's broken in pieces, because your pies are always beautiful. Aiden had an idea that some birds might have gotten into it! Look, there's a little footprint!"



"Oh goodness," Mom answered, "you guys are right. I guess I'll have to get a screen back on this kitchen window. Well, what do you guys think about going out to get ice cream since the birds ate our pie?"

"Yay!!!" we shouted, and dashed off to the car. Solving mysteries sure makes you hungry!

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